

priced at exactly Rs 15,000, and we could've easily placed it in this segment, but we're strict about rules, and 14,999 isn't equal to 15,000. Moreover, this is a higher-end camera, despite the price.

All the big brands made it into this category—Canon, Sony, Olympus, Nikon and Samsung had one model each here. The sole small-town boy was the Premier DC-8365.

The best looker in this category just has to be the Sony DSC-L1. That dark maroon body contrasts well with the steel grey highlights. The camera is so perfectly finished, we spent some time just passing the model around to just ogle at it.

The sheer quality and the actual fit and finish of the entire body including the all the moveable parts is excellent. Not as excellent as another beauty though—the Nikon S5. Sporting a beautifully finished

gun-grey body, this, too, is a very slim camera, slimmer than the L1, but with a slightly higher profile.

As far as build quality goes, the S5 inches ahead, though the “gorgeous” award is still very much in Sony DSC-L1 territory! The Nikon S5 also had that definitively solid feel in the hand; the same can be said for Sony DSC L-1, but it wasn't so noticeable with the other models.

The Canon PowerShot A530 looks unassuming; nothing too special, but decent and solid. Olympus' SP310 was a more attractive dark grey, while the A530 sported the silver. Build quality-wise, the Canon and Olympus were similar.

There were no real losers here as far as build quality and looks go (all the models were above what is considered acceptable), but someone has to bring up the rear—and those positions go to the Samsung Digimax S-500 and the Premier DC-8365.

The crispest screen belonged to the Samsung S500, followed by the 2.5-inch TFT on the Olympus SP-310. The Canon A530, too, had a good screen, but it's a little small at 1.8 inches. The Premier DC-8365, too, was measly



Canon PowerShot A530
Doesn't quite live up to its name

How We Tested

We received 25 digital cameras for our shootout. For the sake of simplicity and to enable correct and informed buying decisions within a particular price bracket, we decided to segregate the cameras we received into three price zones.

Price Brackets

First we have the entry-level or budget segment. To qualify here, cameras needed to be priced below Rs 8,500. We set 8,500 as a ceiling because this is typically the maximum amount that a budget-conscious user will spend.

The next category is the pricier and more feature-filled segment. All the cameras that fell within the price bracket of above Rs 8,500 and below Rs 15,000 were included in this category.

Last came the 15,000 and above segment: these cameras, of course, offer better performance than the lower-priced models. Such cameras can also be considered by photography enthusiasts. These are by no means professional cameras—true professional cameras could start from as much as Rs 40,000! We didn't cap the price for cameras in this segment.

Features

The features we looked for included the megapixel rating of the CCD sensor, the degree of optical zoom provided, the number of shooting modes, the presence of a flash, and the number of flash modes present. We also checked for the metering modes available, shutter speeds, white balance settings and autofocus options. Presence of macro shooting mode, its minimum range, the presence of an optical viewfinder, the size and clarity of the LCD viewfinder, and video-out capabilities were also noted. We awarded points to a good bundle, and the presence of a memory card, a battery charger, and a USB docking / recharge station was also rewarded appropriately.

Testing Scenarios

We kept the ISO value at Auto during all the test shots. Similar lighting conditions were used to ensure a level playing field. The white balance was set to Auto. Digital zoom was turned off for cameras that supported the feature. We used the maximum MP rating of the cameras for all the tests. The flash was turned off, since it causes loss of finer detail, assuming decent lighting. A flash also causes reflections and the bloom effect in certain shots. We did a separate flash test to check their effective range. We used a tripod all through to rule out camera shake.



Our tabletop scene. Note the number of diverse elements!

1. The tabletop scene: This consisted of fruit of various kinds, a glass partially filled with a soft drink, and three soft drink cans—one was bright red, one was blue, and the third was orange and green. There were a number of paper clips strewn in a heap, with a few odds and ends thrown in for good measure. All this was placed on a wrinkled satin cloth. This shot allowed us to check for quality of detail, sharpness, colour and contrast, and white balance.

2. The outdoor shoot: We took several shots of our office building and of the greenery around. This type of photography allows for testing of the quality of the metering modes, along

with the effectiveness of the white balance at the Auto setting. We also checked for fine details, such as the texture and appearance of the veins on the leaves, and subtle variations in colour.

3. Up close and personal: A simple yet elegant watch was used in a macro shot. The close-up of the dial with all its minute calibrations presents an opportunity to test both the camera's macro range as well as its capabilities in this mode.

4. The video test: We shot videos to check for the quality during video shoot, and for audio clarity. The videos were checked for dropping of frames (jerky playback) and, of course, loss in quality.